DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

How Close Will You Sit in the World to Come?

Daat Tevunot §72-76

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §72 (second half) to §76 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Tuesday 24 January 2023

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Review: why the soul cannot finish its work now

The Rabbi opened with questions. What is the purpose of the Neshamah in a person's makeup? Not only to overcome the body, but to elevate and refine it. Why can it not do so completely in this life? Two reasons. Because of the sin of Adam, the body must pass through death before body and soul are reunited at tehiyat hametim. And the soul itself has been reduced, like the moon, in order to live with the body; one day, like the moon, it will shine at full strength, no longer with its wings clipped.

§72: the soul's two entries into the body

The Ramhal continues. The soul comes from a pure and exalted source. To enter this coarse body and stay with it for a lifetime, it is brought down and minimised, and given the laws of the Torah to keep while it is there. Because it is minimised, it cannot ignite the body now. But whatever it does is remembered.

The first time the soul enters the body, at birth, it must make itself small. The second time, at the resurrection, it comes with all its light to complete the refinement and return the body "honourable and clear". This, the Rabbi said, is the beauty of the soul: it goes through different stages in order to refine the body. And in completing the body, the soul itself is elevated. You cannot compare the soul of a person who studied Torah, did misvot and came to some understanding of the divine with a soul that lacks all this.

Even the most elevated soul can rarely change the body visibly in this world. Only a very few manage that. But anyone who has a place in olam haba, which the vast majority of people will, must have the body elevated, because "you cannot be in olam haba with your body which you have today", a body with impulses.

Is it unfair to the soul?

Moshe asked: the soul is reduced when it enters the body, and then, through no fault of its own, it goes up only to the level the person reached. Isn't that unfair to the soul?

The Rabbi answered that the question treats the soul as though it had an identity of its own. It does not. Like an angel, which is a messenger that does its job, the soul has a job: to enter the

body. "The soul is you. The soul is your brain, it's your consciousness, it's who you are." What you make of it is up to you.

Another participant suggested numbers: you reach 99 in this life, die, and after the resurrection the soul completes the rest. The Rabbi agreed that every body will be elevated, but your seat depends on what you did. You will have the seat of 99, not of 100.

What is the reward? The Queen analogy

Asked what the soul will actually do in olam haba, the Rabbi turned it back to the group: what is the ultimate good? To cleave to HaKadosh Barukh Hu.

He gave an analogy he has used before. Imagine being invited to tea with the late Queen, and imagine you would never get bored. People prepare for years for such an invitation. How long you could spend with her, and how near you could sit, would depend on how much you had refined yourself: your manners, your etiquette, your bearing. "Now it's not a reward. It's just the consequences." That is olam haba: "the identity you have created for yourself". A decent person sits somewhere in the middle, an excellent person near the front, and a rotten person may not get in at all.

Even watching the Queen eat lunch from a few tables back would draw a crowd; the thrill of those first thirty minutes would last forever. When Ellis joked that he would bring his own takeaway because the food would not be kosher, the Rabbi turned it into the point: you cannot bring takeaway food into the palace. Just so, there are certain sins that remove a person's ability to connect to the divine altogether. Most of us will enter; the question is how close.

§73-74: the Ramhal's summary

The Neshamah asks for a summary, and the Sekhel gives it. A human being is made of two parts. The body is dark and full of imperfection, but can be elevated by the soul. The soul is of great origin, reduced when it enters the body so that it does not change the body at once, and works on it slowly. In the world to come it will be elevated according to its deeds, and the greater the person, the greater the elevation, until he can delight in the pleasantness of God and be in His sanctuary forever.

Whose fault is a sin?

A participant asked: if the soul does all the work, is a sin the soul's fault? The Rabbi went back to Derech Hashem. The body by itself is just flesh. What gives it life is the nefesh habehemit, the lowest of the five levels of the soul (nefesh, ruah, neshamah, hayah, yehidah), which every animal has. It produces the drives to eat, drink and reproduce. The higher part of the soul fights against those drives.

"You are in between the body and the soul. It's up to you to decide. Now you chose bad, it's your fault." The participant summed up: the soul is me, I made a bad choice, and I am responsible. "Correct."

§75-76: what comes next

The Neshamah says: you have explained the resurrection and the reward of the world to come; now finish what we began. The Rabbi recapped the three topics. The essence of man is body and soul. His actions in this world are meant to bring the soul to master the body. The consequence is the resurrection, their reunion.

In §76 the Sekhel says that, having explained man's essence and the stages of the soul, he must now explain how God relates to man, both to his body and to his soul, in these different periods. That is the topic of the next class.

Summary

- The soul enters the body twice: reduced at birth, so that there is free choice, and in full light at the resurrection, to complete the body's refinement.
- The soul is not a separate being with its own grievances; it is our own consciousness, and we are responsible for our choices.
- Olam haba is closeness to God, like time with the Queen: not a payment but the identity we have built.
- §73-74: the body is lowly, the soul is reduced, and each person is elevated in the end according to his deeds.
- §76 opens the next topic: how God relates to body and soul in each period.

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